

MASTER METHOD for HIGHLAND BAGPIPE

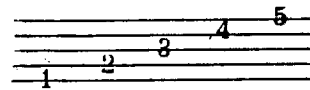
THEORY

MUSIC: A succession of sounds, so modulated as to please the ear.

MUSICAL SOUNDS: The result of rapid and regular vibrations of the air, they may be high or low pitched. When high pitched the vibrations are rapid and when low pitched the vibrations are slow.

MUSICAL SOUNDS ARE PRODUCED by forcing a column of air through the practice chanter which causes the blades of the reed to vibrate.

MUSICAL SOUNDS ARE EXPRESSED ON PAPER by providing a written language or notation, *having two essentials*—(1) PITCH, which is obtained by a series of five lines and four spaces; (2) by using the Clef sign.



MUSICAL NOTES are characters by which musical sounds are represented on the staff. Named after the first seven letters of the alphabet: A, B, C, D, E, F, G.

The names of the notes on the lines are



and in the spaces



The eighth sound is called the octave or replicate of the first.

TIME: This may mean one of three things in music, i.e. (a) The length and duration of a single sound. (b) The regular recurrence of accents. (c) The pace of a particular movement or melody.

THE NOTES AND THEIR VALUE

Semibreve.

Minim.

Crotchet.

Quaver.

Semiquaver.

Demisemiquaver.



The different forms are used to indicate the various duration of sounds and the proportion they bear to each other is explained by the following table:

A Semibreve is equal in value to:

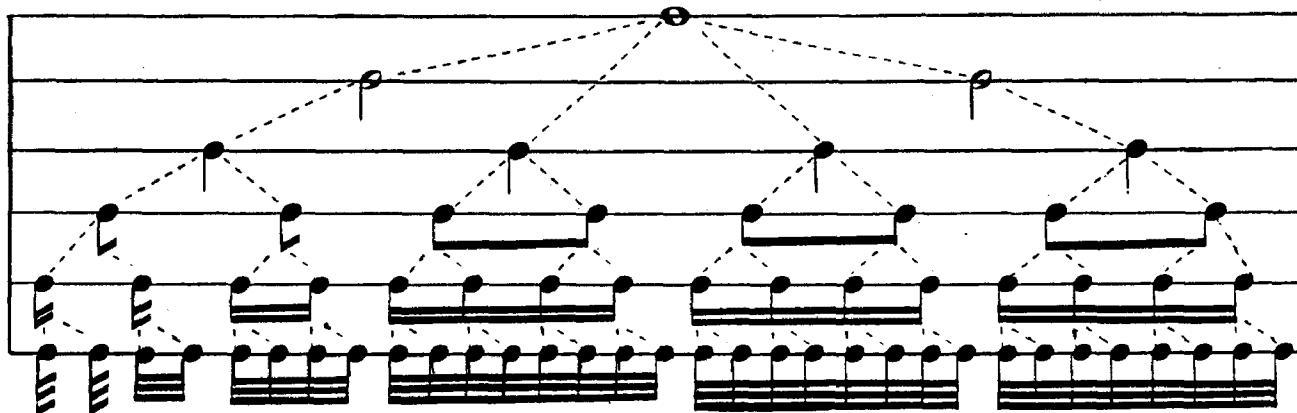
2 Minims, or

4 Crotchets, or

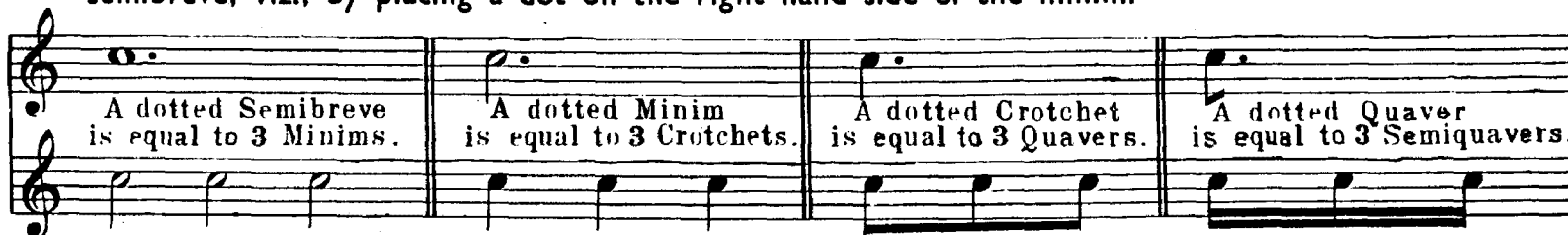
8 Quavers, or

16 Semiquavers, or

32 Demisemiquavers

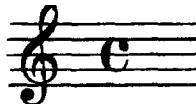


TIME AND DURATION: A sound may be required which will be longer than a minim, but shorter than a semibreve, viz., by placing a dot on the right hand side of the minim.

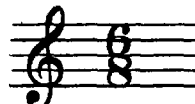


TIME TABLE: Only six time signatures are used in Pipe Music, C 4/4, 2/4 common time, 3/4 triple time, 6/8 9/8 and 12/8 compound time, C Alla Breve Music played in half-time.

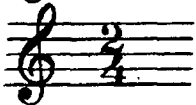
Contains 4 crotchets in a bar, or their equivalents—indicated:—



Contains 6 quavers in a bar, or their equivalents—indicated:—



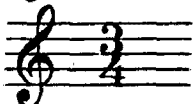
Contains 2 crotchets in a bar, or their equivalents—indicated:—



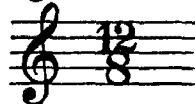
Contains 9 quavers in a bar, or their equivalents—indicated:—



Contains 3 crotchets in a bar, or their equivalents—indicated:—



Contains 12 quavers in a bar, or their equivalents—indicated:—



TIME SIGNATURES: Consist of two figures, as shown above, in fractional form, a semibreve being regarded as the standard note by which all other notes are measured. (See Notes and Their Value, page 2). The lower numbers refer to the division of a semibreve; the top number shows how many of these are in the bar or measure, i.e., 2/4 means two fourths of a semibreve, or two crotchets, or equivalent in a bar.

ACCENT IN MUSIC: Accents signify prominence, stress or force which is given to certain notes more than others. The accents are strong, medium or weak.

The strong accent is marked with more force:—indicated— f

The medium accent is moderately emphasized:— „ — m

The weak accent is taken lightly „ — p

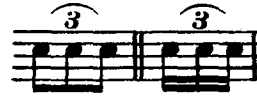


PAUSE MARK: $\frown$ prolongs a note or rest beyond its ordinary time value at the performer's discretion.

A DOT PLACED AFTER A NOTE increases its value by one half.

A dotted Semibreve is equal to 3 Minims.	A dotted Minim is equal to 3 Crotchets.	A dotted Crotchet is equal to 3 Quavers.	A dotted Quaver is equal to 3 Semiquavers.
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TRIPLETS: Occasionally three notes of equal value are written to be performed in the time of two of the same kind. By placing the figure 3 above or below the group, it becomes a triplet.



PITCH: Is the depth of a musical sound. It also denotes the relation one note has to the other, in being high or low, indicated by its position on the stave.

VARIATION: Means the different ways of expressing or presenting the same air, each time containing something new. A variation in Pipe Music is better known as 1st or 2nd time.

CHORDS: Are notes of different pitches played in perfect harmony.

STRAIN: A musical subject forming part of, and having relation to a general whole. A Piobaireachd is usually in 3 strains.

CADENCE: Is a succession of notes leading from one phrase to another thus being an embellishment to the next note.

PHRASING: Is giving expression and feeling to a piece of music.

PHRASE: A short musical sentence, or sub-division of a musical period; a musical thought or idea.

RHYTHM: To produce an agreeable effect in music by a regular succession of motions.

THEME: The air or melody being the principal subject of a musical composition, from which all the variations are derived.

INCOMPLETE BARS: In Bagpipe Music it frequently occurs that there is an incomplete bar at the beginning and the end of a tune. If the incomplete bars are added together it will be found that they make exactly the value of one complete bar.

BAR LINES: To divide the strain into equal parts. The bar being drawn vertically across the stave. A double bar marks the end of the strain. When dots are placed on either side of the double bar they signify that strain, or period on such side be repeated.

GRACE NOTE or APPOGGIATURA: A grace note, although an embellishment, is played with the fingering of a melody note, but is not counted in the time of music.

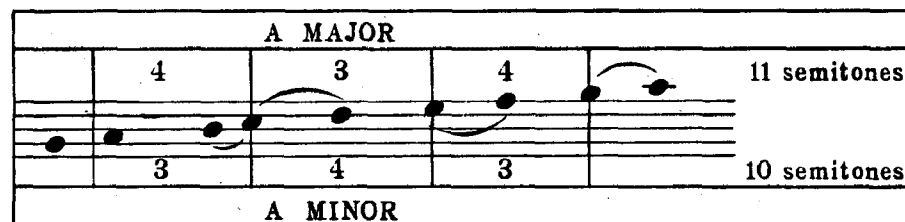
STAVE: The five lines on which musical notes are written:



tone: A sound considered as to pitch.

LEGER LINE: When necessary the stave is extended by adding short lines called "leger lines." These lines and spaces to which they give rise are named in alphabetical order. In bagpipe music only one leger line is used and is placed above the stave.

BAGPIPE SCALE:



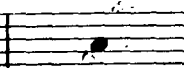
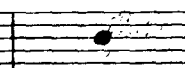
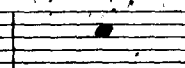
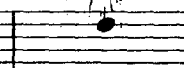
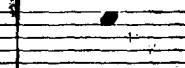
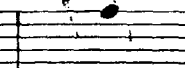
The chanter of the bagpipe is limited in all to nine notes and to the scale of A MAJOR which requires three sharps. The example above illustrates the transposition of the semitones to A MAJOR from their natural positions in A MINOR.

The scale is divided into three thirds, and the number of semitones in each third are marked.

The original positions of the semitones are marked under the notes as they occur in A MINOR, and the positions to which they are raised by the sharps A MAJOR (in the Bagpipe Scale) are marked above the notes remembering that a sharp ($\sharp$) raises the note to which it refers a semitone, and a (b) in the same manner depresses the note to which it refers a semitone.

SCALE AND FINGERING

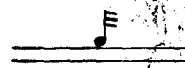
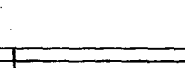
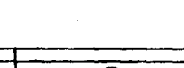
SCALE:

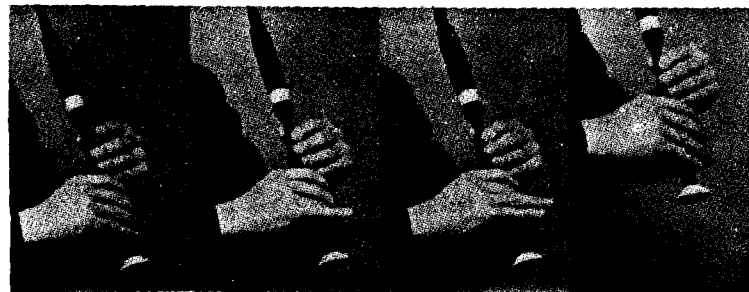
								
LOW G	LOW A	B	C	D	E	F	HIGH G	HIGH A

FINGERING:



HOW TO PLAY A HIGH "G" GRACE NOTE ON A LOW "G" See Exercise No. 2.

					
G	A	B	G	A B C A	B C D B



EXERCISES

No. 1. Place all fingers on the chanter, left hand to the top as per diagram on page 6, raise little finger of right hand followed by fourth finger, then return all fingers to the chanter and so on up the scale.



No. 2. EXERCISE WITH G GRACE NOTE:

Grace notes are not usually fingered according to scale, the topmost finger of the movement only being used. Thus, to produce G grace note raise and put down first finger top hand. All the full notes in this exercise require to be fingered as shown in the scale.



No. 3. A HIGH SHAKE:

This shake is composed of two grace notes, high A and G joined, and is performed by simply sounding high A and passing the thumb with a smart downward movement over the hole in the back of the chanter. In coming to high A from any of the bottom hand notes, care must be taken not to put down bottom hand before top hand is raised. The movement of the hands requires to be simultaneous, otherwise the result is a catch or short note between them.



EXERCISES

No. 4. HIGH G SHAKE:

This shake is composed of the two grace notes G and F joined. The G is not fingered according to the scale, as the whole top hand, except thumb, requires to be raised, it being more convenient to strike the F that way. The shake therefore is performed by raising the 1st, 2nd and 3rd fingers, top hand, the little finger of the lower hand being also raised, and striking the top hole of the chanter smartly with 1st finger. In shifting fingers from high G of this exercise care must be taken not to put down G before raising the next note, otherwise the fingering will not be clean.



No. 5. F SHAKE:

This movement is composed of grace notes G, F, G, joined, and is performed by raising 1st, 2nd and 3rd fingers of top hand, always having the little finger raised, put down 1st finger, raise and put it down again. This striking of top finger twice gives you G, F, G, shake and full note F, the last note of the movement.



No. 6. E SHAKE:

This shake consists of grace notes G, E, F, joined, and is performed by raising 1st, 2nd and 3rd fingers top hand, little finger of course being up also, put down 1st finger, then raise 2nd finger and put it down. Be sure one finger is down before the other is raised. Always sound the first note of each group before performing shake.



EXERCISES

No. 7. D SHAKE:

This consists of notes low G, D, C, joined, and is performed by blowing the chanter on low G and then raising 1st, 2nd and 3rd fingers of bottom hand and striking 1st finger smartly on the hole.

**No. 8. C SHAKE:**

This shake is also composed of three grace notes, G, C, D, and is performed by raising G grace note on C and smartly moving the D finger, thus returning to C. The "C" grace note is accounted for by the pause between the "G" grace note on C and the D grace note on C.



with thumb grace notes

**No. 9. MISCELLANEOUS SHAKES :**

Using G, low G, D—G; low A, D—G; D—G, B, D,—G, C, D—G, D, E, G, F, G, and the No. 3 Exercise on page 7.



EXERCISES

No. 10. GRACE NOTING:

which takes up both hands (G—D—E—and D grace notes).

**No. 11. TAORLUATH MOVEMENT:**

Change from low A to low A by putting in a G grace note, close the chanter to low G, make a D grace note and go to low A, putting in an E grace note as the change is made. The movement on D* is produced by playing a B grace note instead of a D grace note on low G.

**No. 12:**

The same movement as No. 11 less the E grace note, only the performer returns to the initial starting note, viz., B to B, not B to A as in No. 11.



EXERCISES

No. 13:

In this movement the B grace note is used, but this occurs only when playing from D. The 2nd movement in this exercise is seldom played, but can be performed by playing from low G, putting in a D grace note on low G, a C grace note on low G and return to B.



No. 14. LITTLE FINGER MOVEMENT:

or better known to everyday pipers as the "BIRL."

This can be performed by firstly tapping the little finger of the right hand on the chanter smartly. Do this twice, making the grace notes low G, low A, low G and return to low A. Once the learner has achieved a certain amount of speed in this double tap of the little finger, he should proceed then to draw the little finger across the chanter straight, still keeping the double tap effect. The movement can be enhanced by adding a G grace note to the first low A.



GENERAL INSTRUCTIONS: In addition to the scale and exercises which he learns by means of the practice chanter it is desirable that the beginner should learn to blow the bagpipe.

An easy method of acquiring the art of keeping a steady flow of wind is to fit the practice chanter into a goose—a small bag without drones. After a little practice no difficulty will be found in keeping an even flow of air, and when the bagpipe is finally attempted the pupil should be able to keep it going with ease. The drones are held on the left shoulder. When tuning, the left hand holds the chanter (stopping the notes A, G and F) while the right hand lengthens or shortens the drones. The bag being filled with air, maintain an even pressure with the arm, which pressure is slightly increased while drawing breath. To begin with the pupil should not attempt to keep more than one drone going.

TUNING: Tune one small drone to low A on the chanter, the second small drone to the first, and the bass drone last, also to the first small drone. If the drones have to be unduly lengthened, the reed is sharp. To flatten it, move the girdle-string downwards, towards the open end. If the drones have to be completely shortened the reed is flat. To sharpen it, move the girdle-string upwards, thus shortening the tongue.

CHANTER REEDS: Tune one of the small drones to low A, and sound it with high A: if the drone is in tune with it the chanter reed is set right. Should the drone require to be tuned out to bring it into tune, then the chanter reed is too flat, and must be put further into the chanter. If the drone requires to be moved down to bring it in tune, the chanter reed is too sharp and therefore must be lifted up a little. Accuracy is required in moving the chanter reed as very small changes in position result in great alterations in pitch.

PRESERVATION OF THE BAG: The bag must be kept airtight, otherwise the even flow of air necessary to maintain the steady tone from the reeds cannot be maintained. Should the bag require dressing at any time, the procedure is as follows: Remove drones, chanter and blowpipe from the bag, remove tartan cover, cork up all five stocks. Pour into the bag, by the middle tenor drone stock, half a tin of "Airtight" seasoning. Massage the bag thoroughly all over, then hang up by the small loop at the end of the bag, and allow the excess dressing to drain out by the chanter stock. When all the excess dressing is drained out, remove the other four cords, see that there is no dressing in the stocks, and the bag is then ready for using again.